

| 1978 | KISSA KURSI KA Celluloid Chutzpah

The film's ban signalled the begining of the end of Sanjay Gandhi's reign

The Shabana Azmi starrer was India's first political spoof and its title—*Kissa Kursi Ka* (KKK)—has become part of the political lexicon. With dialogues like "Sir, give this young man the licence to manufacture small cars because he learnt it in his mother's womb", it took on the most powerful man of India then, Sanjay Gandhi. In the film, the main political party had a 'people's car' as its election symbol, an obvious take-off on Sanjay's Maruti car project. Obviously Indira Gandhi's errant son, then leading an unbridled youth brigade, known as Sanjay

Gandhi's storm-troopers, was not amused. The film's negative, all the prints and the master-print were lifted from CBFC office, brought to the Maruti factory in Gurgaon and burned. The film, however, gave a powerful handle to the Jayaprakash Narayan-led movement and later to the Janata Party in destroying the Indira Gandhi-led Congress in the 1977 Lok Sabha polls. The Shah Commission, set up to examine the Emergency excesses, held Sanjay guilty for burning the prints. As the Supreme Court denied him bail, Sanjay had to spend a month in Tihar Jail. V.C. Shukla, I&B minister in Indira Gandhi's cabinet, also faced trial for allegedly destroying the prints of KKK and was jailed for two years. The verdict was overturned later. Though very few could see the film directed by Amrit Nahata, its title became immortal. During the anti-Emergency campaign, Nahata, a former Congress MP from Rajasthan, had been catapulted to stardom. He made the film again in 1978 with a new

cast. Despite the controversy and massive publicity, the new movie proved to be a disaster. Even his commercially-oriented decision to replace Azmi with busty calendar girl Katy Mirza could not save the film. In a letter to the then I&B minister L.K. Advani, Nahata demanded Rs 1 crore as compensation claiming that "were KKK released even now, it would have broken all box office records". Prior to KKK, Nahata had made a devotional movie *Sant Gyaneshwar* in 1965 and a crime thriller *Raton Ka Raja* in 1967. He died on April 26, 2001, aged 74. He did not stand for Parliament or make a film again.

by Farzand Ahmed

THE MAIN EVENT

Left Comes to Power in West Bengal

Dressed in a spotless dhoti and kurta, Jyoti Basu personifies the change that has taken place in the Communist Party of India's (Marxist) image. A fiery orator, he was once the picture of a militant Marxist. Gone are the days in Bengal when the likes of Kanoria-Jajodia-Khaitan would wake up sweating at night, having seen Basu's face in a nightmare. The business community now finds him "such a charming fellow". They feel he is not such "a rabble-rousing ruffian" after all. He now discourages *gheraos*, attempts to solve industrial disputes amicably (though he is "a bit irritating" on that score) and in general works hard and honestly to provide more primary schools, road repairs, and other such services. According to them, he is making a sincere effort to solve the major problems of the state, like the power shortage, unemployment and rising prices.

India Today, April 15, 1978



A FIERY ORATOR, JYOTI BASU WAS ONCE THE PICTURE OF A MILITANT MARXIST

ALSO

- Morarji Desai objects to an international inspection of India's nuclear installations
- Air India Flight 855 crashes off Bandra, killing 213
- Polio immunisation programme for children begins

THE SECOND VERSION OF KKK WAS PRODUCED ON A BUDGET OF RS 14 LAKH, CLAIMED NAHATA.